

Season of bluster: On Trump, Putin and Ukraine

Trump is finding it difficult to **negotiate** with Putin on Ukraine

After more than two months of **caustic** words for Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and **approbation** for Russian President Vladimir Putin, U.S. President Donald Trump appeared to **strike a** different **note** in his approach towards bringing the two leaders to the negotiating table. **Following** a call with Mr. Putin, Mr. Trump said that he was “very angry” with the former when, following weeks of attempted negotiations, Mr. Putin reportedly attacked Mr. Zelenskyy’s **credibility** instead of discussing steps towards finding peace. Further, **Mr. Trump**, **apparently irate** that his campaign promise to end the conflict was **losing steam** and in danger of remaining unfulfilled, **threatened** to **slap** nations purchasing Russian oil with a 50% tariff, unless Mr. Putin agreed to a **ceasefire in the near term**. The **choke point** was Mr. Putin’s **insistence** that Mr. Zelenskyy **lacks** the **legitimate** authority to sign a **robust** peace deal that would not be challenged by any nation; and that in this context the introduction of “temporary governance in Ukraine,” was required, **perhaps** achieved through “democratic elections, to bring to power a **viable** government that enjoys the trust of the people...”

In terms of his popularity **back home**, Mr. Zelenskyy had earlier corrected a **broadside** from Mr. Trump, a false claim that he only had an **approval rating** of 4%, when in fact **Kiev** had noted that 65% of Ukrainians trusted their President and his approval rating **hovered** around 57% in early 2025. Mr. Putin’s **claims in this regard**, which range from the **unfounded** statements about Mr. Zelenskyy lacking popular **legitimacy** to **accusing** him, a leader of Jewish descent, **of** enabling Nazi forces in Ukraine, **can** be understood **in the backdrop of** Moscow’s **reluctance** to enter into a peace treaty at a time when its troops have continued to keep up the military pressure on Ukrainian forces and have made **substantial territorial** gains there. The greater **concern** for Europe, and perhaps the U.S., **might** be that Mr. Putin could **seek** to **undermine** via influence operations any plan for free and fair elections in Ukraine and thus succeed in getting a pro-Russian candidate installed in Kiev. In turn, Mr. **Trump**, even if he is not particularly concerned with European security in a post-conflict **scenario** in Ukraine that might favour Russian interests, **may** worry that a **lucrative** U.S.-Ukraine mineral **extraction** deal might be in **jeopardy** if Mr. Putin is **de facto calling the shots** across the region. **Regardless of** the bluster on all sides, an early ceasefire would have the greatest impact on **prospects** for **lasting** peace after more than three years of **bloodshed** and **dislocation**.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

Vocabulary

1. **Bluster** (noun) – loud, aggressive, or indignant talk with little effect. धमकी
2. **Negotiate** (verb) – Bargain, Mediate, Arbitrate, Conciliate, Broker वार्ता करना
3. **Caustic** (adjective) – Sarcastic, Biting, Cutting, Sharp, Acidic कटु
4. **Approbation** (noun) – Approval, Praise, Commendation, Endorsement, Sanction अनुमोदन
5. **Strike a note** (phrase) – to express and communicate a particular opinion or feeling about something.
6. **Following** (preposition) – After, Subsequent to, In the wake of, As a result of के बाद
7. **Credibility** (noun) – Trustworthiness, Reliability, Believability, Integrity, Plausibility विश्वसनीयता
8. **Apparently** (adverb) – Seemingly, Ostensibly, Evidently, Clearly, Obviously प्रत्यक्ष रूप से
9. **Irate** (adjective) – Angry, Furious, Enraged, Incensed, Wrathful क्रोधित
10. **Losing steam** (phrase) – Weakening, Flagging, Declining, Fading, Slowing कमजोर पड़ना
11. **Slap** (verb) – Impose, Levy, Apply, Inflict, Force थोपना
12. **Ceasefire** (noun) – Truce, Armistice, Peace agreement, Suspension of hostilities युद्धविराम
13. **In the near term** (phrase) – Soon, Shortly, In the immediate future, Before long निकट भविष्य में
14. **Choke point** (noun) – Bottleneck, Constriction, Blockage, Obstruction, Impasse अवरोध बिंदु
15. **Insistence** (noun) – Demand, Assertion, Persistence, Urging, Pressure ज़ोर
16. **Lack** (verb) – Be without, Need, Want, Require, Miss अभाव होना
17. **Legitimate** (adjective) – Valid, Legal, Lawful, Authorized, Genuine वैध
18. **Robust** (adjective) – Strong, Sturdy, Vigorous, Resilient, Durable मजबूत
19. **Perhaps** (adverb) – Maybe, Possibly, Conceivably, Perchance, Potentially शायद
20. **Viable** (adjective) – Feasible, Workable, Practical, Achievable, Sustainable व्यवहार्य
21. **In terms of** (phrase) – Regarding, Concerning, With respect to, In relation to के संदर्भ में
22. **Back home** (phrase) – In one's own country अपने ही देश में

23. **Broadside** (noun) – Attack, Criticism, Rebuke, Tirade, Diatribe आलोचना
24. **Approval rating** (noun) – The percentage of respondents to an opinion poll who express approval of someone or something, typically a political figure.
25. **Kiev** (noun) – Ukrainian capital कीव
26. **Hover** (around) (verb) – Fluctuate, Oscillate, Waver, Linger, Remain near मंडराना
27. **In this regard** (phrase) – In this respect, On this matter, Concerning this, Regarding this इस संबंध में
28. **Unfounded** (adjective) – Baseless, Groundless, Unsubstantiated, False, Untrue निराधार
29. **Legitimacy** (noun) – Validity, Lawfulness, Authenticity, Authority, Rightfulness वैधता
30. **Accuse** (of) (verb) – Charge, Blame, Indict, Impeach, Denounce आरोप लगाना
31. **In the backdrop of** (phrase) – Against the background of, In the context of, Considering की पृष्ठभूमि में
32. **Reluctance** (noun) – Unwillingness, Hesitation, Disinclination, Resistance, Aversion अनिच्छा
33. **Substantial** (adjective) – Significant, Considerable, Large, Ample, Sizeable पर्याप्त
34. **Territorial** (adjective) – Geographical, Regional, Zonal, Spatial, Landrelated प्रादेशिक
35. **Seek** (verb) – try, attempt, effort, endeavour, प्रयास करना
36. **Undermine** (verb) – Weaken, Sabotage, Subvert, Erode, Damage कमजोर करना
37. **Scenario** (noun) – Situation, Circumstance, Case, Context, Setting परिदृश्य
38. **Lucrative** (adjective) – Profitable, Rewarding, Gainful, Paying, Fruitful लाभदायक
39. **Extraction** (noun) – Mining, Removal, Drawing out, Withdrawal, Derivation निष्कर्षण
40. **Jeopardy** (noun) – Danger, Risk, Peril, Hazard, Threat खतरा
41. **De facto** (adjective) – Actual, Effective, In practice, In reality, Existing वास्तविक
42. **Call the shots** (phrase) – Control, Dominate, Command, Decide, Rule नियंत्रण करना
43. **Regardless of** (phrase) – Despite, In spite of, Irrespective of, Notwithstanding के बावजूद
44. **Prospect** (noun) – Outlook, Possibility, Potential, Expectation, Likelihood संभावना

45. **Lasting** (adjective) – Enduring, Permanent,
Longterm, Persistent, Durable स्थायी

46. **Bloodshed** (noun) – Slaughter, Carnage,
Killing, Violence, Massacre खून-खराबा

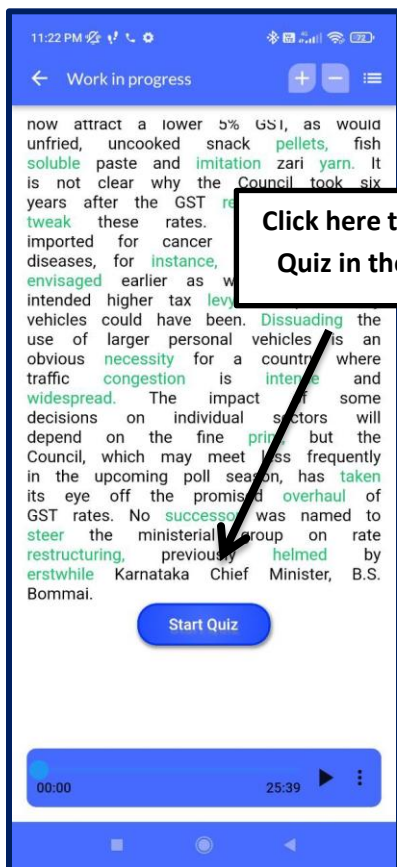
47. **Dislocation** (noun) – Disruption,
Disturbance, Disorder, Displacement, Upset
विस्थापन

@mocks_wallah

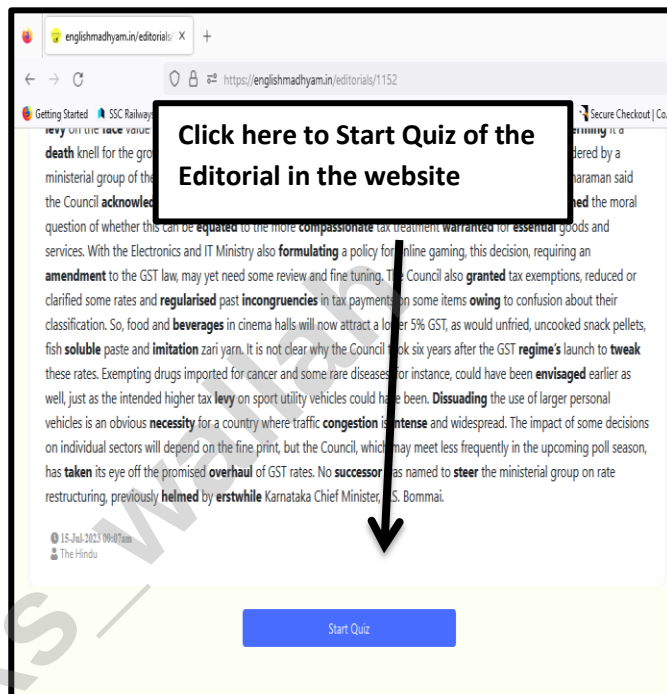
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Trump's shifting stance:** After initially praising Putin and criticizing Zelenskyy, Trump changed his tone after a call with Putin, expressing anger over stalled negotiations.
2. **Putin's refusal to engage:** Instead of discussing peace, Putin attacked Zelenskyy's credibility, derailing negotiations.
3. **Trump's frustration:** Trump is upset that his campaign promise to end the Ukraine conflict remains unfulfilled.
4. **Economic threats:** Trump threatened a 50% tariff on nations buying Russian oil unless Putin agrees to a ceasefire.
5. **Putin's demands:** Putin insists Zelenskyy lacks legitimacy and proposes "temporary governance" in Ukraine, possibly through new elections.
6. **Zelenskyy's popularity:** Contrary to Trump's false claim of a 4% approval rating, Zelenskyy enjoys 57% approval and 65% trust among Ukrainians.
7. **Putin's propaganda:** Moscow spreads unfounded claims, including that Zelenskyy (of Jewish descent) supports Nazi forces in Ukraine.
8. **Russia's military gains:** Putin avoids peace talks while Russian troops maintain pressure and gain territory in Ukraine.
9. **Election interference fears:** Europe and the U.S. worry Putin may manipulate Ukrainian elections to install a pro-Russian leader.
10. **Trump's economic concerns:** Beyond European security, Trump fears a U.S.-Ukraine mineral extraction deal could collapse under Russian influence.
11. **Geopolitical stakes:** The conflict's outcome could reshape regional power dynamics in favor of Russia.
12. **Bluster vs. reality:** Despite tough rhetoric, meaningful progress toward peace remains elusive.
13. **Ceasefire urgency:** An immediate ceasefire is crucial to ending three years of war and displacement.
14. **Long-term peace challenges:** Lasting stability depends on fair governance and resisting Russian interference.
15. **Global implications:** The situation tests U.S. and European resolve in countering Putin's expansionist policies.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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